



WHALES

Millions of years ago whales used to walk. Since then, they have changed a lot. They have grown bigger and bigger, their back legs have disappeared, and their front legs have turned into flippers. They can't live on land anymore, but they are still mammals. This means that they breathe air and feed their babies milk.

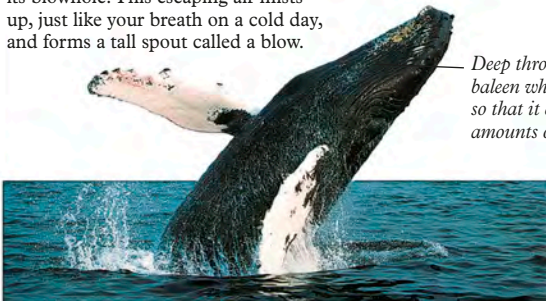
There are two sorts of whales: those that have teeth and those that do not. Whales that have no teeth are called baleen whales.

The whale moves its tail up and down to push itself through the sea. The fastest whale is the sei. It can reach speeds of 40 miles (64 kilometers) an hour, 10 times faster than a person can swim.



There she blows!

When a whale surfaces to fill its lungs with fresh air, warm air escapes from its blowhole. This escaping air mists up, just like your breath on a cold day, and forms a tall spout called a blow.



Deep throat grooves let a baleen whale's mouth stretch so that it can hold vast amounts of water and krill.



Krill for supper

Baleen whales eat krill, a kind of plankton. A large whale can eat two tons a day—half the weight of an elephant!

No animal has longer flippers than a humpback whale—they are about 16 feet (five meters) long, almost the height of a giraffe.

Whales have thick fat, called blubber.

Jumping for joy

Humpback whales love to leap right out of the water. This is called breaching. When they crash back into the sea, they make a huge splash!